

The flip side however was we realised that it is more of 'our' thing. There's a whole lot of expertise that is required to really get something meaningful done on a platform like Azure. There was a tremendous amount of restraint that we saw in many of the developers regarding what could be done on the Microsoft platform.

This feeling is now slowly going away and it actually takes a while because that was a platform we had just launched and people were not sure or aware of what they could do on Azure.

However, I think as we moved forward and owing to the amount of interaction that we have had over time with the communities, the comfort levels of developers working on the Azure platform have improved, tremendously.

Q Coming back to the Imagine Cup. Does this imply that you want ideas that are implemented on the Windows platform?

MN: Not at all. The Imagine Cup is for students in India and across the globe. It is actually being driven as part of our engagement with the student community to foster innovation in the student community. It isn't really about anything to do with one specific platform or product.

It's only the 'idea' that is of paramount importance, and it is solely on the merit of the idea that it is actually judged. There obviously has to be an element of realisation of how and for what purpose it will be utilised.

Q Is India important for you (Microsoft) in terms of establishing a development base or industrial base?

GR: Can't speak about the Microsoft perspective, but from my perspective--after spending 19 years of my life in this space and making sure that I have enough customers, I am happy to say that I am right now interacting both with developers and business decision makers. At the end of the day, to me, it is really about open source relationships.

Of course, India is a very important market as well as a development base for Microsoft. You've just got to believe that some things just go together and come one after another. If you have a great developer system, you are ready to adapt, and then will be able to build successful partnerships.

Q Does your team (open source) also engage with the CIOs and IT managers' community?

GR: I have a team that is responsible for meeting a very select group of 50 or so top CIOs from Fortune 500 companies, once a year. However, this team, called the Customer Council, works throughout the year with them. The team was constituted a few years ago. It has been greatly effective in letting us know what the customers really want from us. So we have these very open dealings with people specifying, 'We like this', 'We don't like this', 'Go fix that up' and so on.

Q In the past interactions, the message that we got is that Microsoft is totally open to open source but Linux as a platform is a competitor. Please comment.

GR: Let me clarify -- we do not compete with Linux.



Mandar explaining how Microsoft connects with Open Source at OSI Days 2011

If anything, we compete with Linux vendors, but it's an important decision to make because our company doesn't compete with a technology.

We have a healthy competition with Red Hat. We also have a healthy competition and collaboration with Novell SUSE.

It is important for us to keep our partnerships, and it is equally important for us to keep our market share growing. But having said that, it's got nothing to do with the Linux community. We are happy that we are contributing to the Linux group.

Q And what about Android?

GR: I don't look at Android per se; I definitely look at the Android developers' community and this is something I want to reach out to. So we have porting apps, API mappings, tool kits, SDKs, and a lot more resources for Android developers to help them develop Android applications that could connect to Microsoft Azure. And these are free-of-cost resources!

Q So essentially, you are making it easy for them to migrate their mobile apps from Android to Azure?

GR: Not only that. Our main message is, "Stay on Android and build your apps on Android but for your server platform, check out Azure--it could be the platform of your choice."

Q In future, is there any chance of us seeing some strong open source products from Microsoft à la Android from Google?

GR: At this age, we are changing; we have become open, and this is all about business decisions and business cases--there are no fixed business models now.

I can give an example of something we announced recently. It was our commitment to the Apache and Hadoop groups. What we are going to do is not only offer the best-of-breed technology but work with the community, so whatever changes they make in the Windows server, we give it back to the community; and second, we maintain compatibility so that users of Hadoop can keep taking their jobs in and out the Windows server and Azure. That's an important step forward. It's a product.